

THE MISSING CHAPTER

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Genre: Psychological Thriller / Mystery

Manuscript Length: 91,000 words

Beta-Reading Stage: First Complete Draft

CHAPTER ONE

Page 217

At 11:37 p.m., Lena Carter finished editing the manuscript.

She leaned back in her chair and rubbed her eyes.

Six hours.

That was how long she'd spent cutting twelve unnecessary pages from a novel that had been far too long to begin with.

The author would probably complain.

Authors always complained.

They loved their words.

Editors were hired to tell them which ones had to disappear.

Lena saved the file.

FINAL_DRAFT_7.docx

She smiled.

"Finally."

Outside her apartment window, rain slid down the glass.

The city below was almost completely dark.

Lena closed the laptop.

She stood.

Then stopped.

Something didn't feel right.

She looked back at the computer.

The screen was still on.

The manuscript had reopened.

Lena frowned.

She hadn't touched the keyboard.

She walked back to the desk.

The page counter at the bottom of the screen read:

217 pages.

She stared.

"No."

The document had contained 216 pages.

She knew that because she had spent the last hour checking the final page numbers.

She clicked the last page.

A new chapter appeared.

There was no title.

Only one sentence.

Lena is reading this.

She laughed.

It was probably a joke from the author.

She scrolled.

The next sentence appeared.

She is sitting at her desk.

Lena's smile disappeared.

She continued reading.

There is a half-empty cup of coffee beside her.

She looked at the cup.

Black coffee.

Two hours old.

Her stomach tightened.

Another line appeared.

The rain has started again.

Lena looked toward the window.

Rain.

She turned back.

The manuscript continued.

She is beginning to understand.

"No."

She closed the document.

The screen went black.

For a moment, there was silence.

Then the computer turned itself back on.

Lena stepped away.

The manuscript opened again.

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The cursor blinked beneath the last sentence.

A new line appeared.

She doesn't believe us.

Lena stared at the screen.

"Who are you?"

Nothing happened.

Then:

That isn't the right question.

Lena's heart began beating faster.

She reached for the power cable.

Before she could unplug it, another sentence appeared.

Ask why Chapter Twenty-Eight was removed.

Lena froze.

She knew the manuscript.

There had been twenty-seven chapters.

She had edited every one.

She had never seen Chapter Twenty-Eight.

Her phone buzzed.

She nearly screamed.

A message from the author.

Did you find the missing chapter?

Lena stared at the message.

She typed:

What missing chapter?

The response arrived immediately.

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Lena's fingers went cold.

She looked at the screen.

The manuscript was still open.

A new sentence appeared.

He knows you're reading.

Lena looked toward the apartment door.

Nothing.

She walked over and checked the lock.

Locked.

She returned to the desk.

The screen had changed again.

This time there was only one sentence.

At 11:43, someone will knock.

Lena looked at the clock.

11:40.

She laughed nervously.

"This is ridiculous."

11:41.

She sat down.

11:42.

The rain grew louder.

11:43.

Three knocks came from the front door.

Lena didn't move.

Three more.

Then silence.

Her phone buzzed.

The author had sent another message.

Don't open the door.

Lena stared at the message.

Then someone on the other side of the door whispered:

"Lena."

She stopped breathing.

It was her voice.